

the best ai music tools for a vocational p

Research made with AI (Claude). A survey of the best AI music tools for a vocational producer in Barcelona who already owns Ableton + Logic, wants commercially usable output, and prefers free-first. State of the field as of June 2026.

TL;DR

- For your situation (you own Ableton + Logic, want commercially usable output, no budget ceiling but free-first instinct), the single highest-leverage spend is NOT a full-song generator -- it's the in-DAW AI you already partly own: Logic Pro 12's free Stem Splitter + Chord ID + AI Session Players, Ableton Live 12.3's free local stem separation, and one paid mastering path. Treat full-song generators (Suno/Udio/etc.) as sketchpads and stem/sample sources, not your release pipeline, because of unresolved copyright-ownership questions and the still-active Sony litigation.
- **When to start paying:** the moment you (1) want to commercially release a generated track (free tiers are non-commercial -- you need Suno Pro at \$8/mo annual or ElevenLabs Starter at \$5/mo), (2) need WAV/stem export or watermark-free output, or (3) are mastering 5+ tracks a year (a LANDR/eMastered subscription beats per-track human mastering). A sensible starter paid stack runs ~25-35 EUR/month; an all-in setup ~70-90 EUR/month plus a few one-time plugin purchases (~650-700 EUR).
- **Biggest reliability caveat:** Suno (Warner-licensed; still fighting Sony/UMG on fair use) still lets you download audio; Udio has had all downloads -- audio, video, AND stems -- DISABLED since its October 2025 UMG settlement, and they were still off as of June 2026, making Udio effectively unusable for getting audio into your DAW right now.

Key findings

1. **You don't need full-song generators for "real" production.** Pure-AI output generally cannot be registered for copyright. Per the U.S. Copyright Office "Copyright and Artificial Intelligence" Report Part 2 (Jan. 29, 2025), outputs are protectable "only where a human author has determined sufficient expressive elements... but not the mere provision of prompts." The EU position is similar. So generators are best as idea generators or stem fodder you build on -- the genuinely useful AI for you lives inside the DAWs you already own.
2. **Two tools you already paid for got dramatically better in early 2026.** Logic

Pro 12 (Jan 28, 2026) added Synth Player (AI Session Player generating synth bass/chord parts) and Chord ID (audio/MIDI -> chord track). Ableton Live 12.3 added free, local, offline stem separation (Music.AI/Moises engine) plus in-DAW Splice search. These cost 0 extra.

3. **Commercial rights gate on the paid tier, not the song.** Suno free = non-commercial; Pro/Premier = commercial use for songs made while subscribed (no retroactive rights for free-tier songs). Udio free = commercial with attribution; paid = commercial without attribution -- but downloads are off entirely.
4. **The legal cloud is real but asymmetric.** Warner settled with both Suno and Udio (late 2025); UMG settled with Udio only (Oct. 29, 2025, a per-generation royalty reported at \$0.002-\$0.005); Sony is still litigating both. Stable Audio, ElevenLabs Music, and Google Lyria are trained on licensed/owned data and are the "clean" choices for sync/commercial reliability.
5. **For mastering, AI is genuinely good enough for hobbyist/vocational release.** Ozone 12 (one-time, in-DAW, maximum control) vs. LANDR/eMastered (cloud subscription, zero-skill). You already have Logic's free Mastering Assistant as a baseline.
6. **EU/Spain note:** plugin prices are usually quoted incl. VAT in EUR (Spain VAT 21%); US SaaS often shows USD ex-VAT and adds Spanish VAT at checkout. Google Lyria 3 full access is available in the EU. No major tool is EU-blocked, but US SaaS (Suno, ElevenLabs, LANDR) process audio on US servers -- a GDPR consideration for unreleased material; local tools keep audio on your machine.

Category A -- Full-song generators (text/prompt-to-song)

Suno (v5 / v5.5; "Suno Studio" on Premier). Free/Basic \$0 (50 credits/day, non-commercial, attribution). Pro \$10/mo or \$8/mo annual (2,500 credits, commercial rights, up to 12 stems, stem separation). Premier \$30/mo or \$24/mo annual (**Suno Studio in-browser DAW with MIDI export**). Commercial rights nuance: Pro/Premier grant commercial use for songs made while subscribed, but Suno's ToS says "Suno makes no representation or warranty that any copyright will vest in any Output," and the Help Center adds "you generally are not considered the owner of the songs." Legal: settled with Warner (Nov 2025); still litigating Sony and UMG (who moved to add 61,026 works). Suno raised \$400M Series D (Bond Capital, June 3, 2026) at a \$5.4B valuation; passed 2M subscribers Feb 2026. Technical: v5 outputs 44.1kHz; vocals widely considered more human than Udio's; up to 12-stem separation on Pro (this matters -- pull stems into Ableton/Logic). Credit trap: failed/regen generations still burn credits. Why: fastest idea-to-song, best vocals, stem export. Don't rely on it for a flagship commercial release given the ownership ambiguity.

Udio (48kHz; "Sessions" editor). Free (10 credits/day + 100/mo, commercial with attribution). Standard \$10/mo (~9 EUR; 2,400 credits, commercial without attribution). Pro \$30/mo. CRITICAL LIMITATION: per Udio's Help Center, since its Oct 29, 2025 UMG partnership, downloading of audio, video and stems has been disabled, still in force as of June 2026. "Udio is the Photoshop, Suno is the Canva." Why not: on pure audio fidelity and control it's the best, but the download lockout is disqualifying until resolved. Monitor for the 2026 licensed-platform launch.

Stable Audio (Stability AI; hosted 3.0 + open weights). Free tier (non-commercial); paid creator tiers unlock full model + commercial rights. Open weights (Stable Audio Open) free to self-host; you only need a paid Enterprise license if your yearly revenue exceeds USD \$1M -- so for you it's effectively free to use commercially. Cleanest legal story: Stable Audio 3.0 (May 2026) trained on AudioSparx's 806,284 licensed files + Freesound Creative Commons, with Audible Magic copyright screening. 44.1kHz, up to ~3-min structured instrumentals. No vocals -- instrumental/sound-design only; self-hostable. Why: best for instrumental beds, textures, electronic/ambient/cinematic and sound design with a clean legal story.

Google Lyria 3 / Lyria 3 Pro (in Gemini, Flow Music, Vertex AI). Lyria 3 (30-sec clips) Feb 2026; Lyria 3 Pro (full 3-min structured songs) March 25, 2026. Free test in Google AI Studio (limited); Gemini AI Plus \$19.99/mo; API ~\$0.08 per full song. Flow Music (flowmusic.app, launched April 18, 2026) reportedly offers full-length Lyria 3 songs free. Commercial rights for paid subscribers; Google offers copyright indemnification; all output carries an inaudible SynthID watermark that survives compression. 48kHz stereo, vocals + timed lyrics (English/Spanish/French/Japanese -- useful in Barcelona), explicit structural control (intro/verse/chorus/bridge) and section-level regeneration -- the best structural control of any generator. Why: best when a track must hit specific structural beats; cleanest big-tech legal posture; EU-available. SynthID may flag as AI at distributors.

ElevenLabs Music (Eleven Music, Aug 2025; Marketplace March 2026). Free (no commercial license). Starter \$5/mo (commercial license begins here). Creator \$11/mo. Pro \$99/mo (44.1kHz PCM via API). The "licensed-first" play -- preemptive deals with Merlin (30,000 indie labels) and Kobalt, ~50/50 royalty parity split. Designed commercially safe for production-music/sync/brand work. Why: cleanest licensing story of the vocal-capable generators and the cheapest commercial entry (\$5/mo). The legally-safe alternative to Suno/Udio.

Riffusion (FUZZ model; folding into Google Flow Music). Free (core generation). Commercial rights poorly documented -- a genuine risk; contact them before commercial use. FUZZ generates full ~3-min songs from text/audio/image prompts. The product is being absorbed into Google Flow Music branding. Why not: free experimentation only; not for commercial reliability given undocumented licensing.

Honorable mentions: Mubert (cleanest legal story -- curated artist pool), Boomy (built-in Spotify pipeline), AIVA (250+ styles, editable), Soundverse, Soundraw. None beats Suno on vocals or Stable Audio on instrumental cleanliness for this use case.

Category B -- In-DAW / production-assistance AI

Stem separation. You already own the two best zero-cost options: Logic Pro Stem Splitter (free in Logic, vocal/drums/bass/other, in-session lossless) and Ableton Live 12.3 Stem Separation (free in Suite, Music.AI/Moises engine, runs locally/offline). Add Demucs (HTDemucs via UVR/StemRoller, free, open-source, best quality outside enterprise, needs a GPU). Others: Moises (cloud + app, free 5 tracks/mo), RipX DAW/Pro (~\$60/\$160 one-time, note-level editing + audio-to-MIDI), iZotope RX 12 Music Rebalance (\$399+, lossless). Verdict: built-in DAW separators rate surprisingly well (Ableton's particularly strong); add Demucs for top quality; only buy RipX for note-level remix surgery + audio-to-MIDI. Bass stems are the weakest category across every tool -- recreate basslines yourself when fidelity matters.

AI mixing/mastering plugins (in-DAW, one-time -- never expire). iZotope Ozone 12 (Elements \$55 / Standard \$219 / Advanced \$499): AI Master Assistant with Custom flow, Stem EQ, Bass Control, Unlimiter, IRC 5 limiter -- the industry standard, works in Ableton & Logic. iZotope Neutron 5 (mixing, ~\$224), Nectar 4 (vocals, ~\$224), Music Production Suite 9 (\$799, bundles it all). sonible smart:EQ 4 (~45-89 EUR, AI spectral balancing + multi-track unmasking), smart:limit (~40 EUR); smart:bundle saves 40%.

AI mastering services (cloud subscription). LANDR (from ~4 EUR/mo basic; Pro \$19/mo = unlimited masters + distribution to 150+ platforms; DAW plugin for in-session mastering -- best default if you release regularly and want distribution bundled). eMastered (~\$15/mo annual up to \$49.99/mo; more manual control, reference matching, Stemify; better warmth for R&B/soul/acoustic/singer-songwriter; mastering only, no distribution). Logic Pro Mastering Assistant (free -- your zero-cost baseline).

Verdict: try Logic's free Mastering Assistant first; for consistent EP results, eMastered (quality/control) or LANDR (if you also want distribution); buy Ozone 12 to own the tool and master in-DAW.

AI sample / loop / MIDI generation (DAW-integrated). Splice (now native in Ableton Live 12.3): Sounds+ \$12.99/mo, Creator \$19.99/mo, or Splice x Ableton \$12.99/mo; "Search with Sound" AI -- drag a clip in, it returns matching loops in your key/tempo; samples cleared for commercial use. Audialab Emergent Drums 2 (one-time ~\$59 / ~\$99-104 bundle): AI generates infinite original royalty-free drum samples from scratch (clean training), VST3/AU + NKS. Lemonade (Seeds/Spawn): AI MIDI +

48kHz audio loops, "fairly trained," royalty-free under 1M streams. Output (Arcade/Co-Producer) and Suno stems also viable as loop sources.

AI music-theory / chord / melody assistants. Scaler 3 (~79-99 EUR): chord suggestion + detection, 1,000+ chord sets, Dynamic Circle of Fifths, modulation suggestions, standalone + plugin, supports Ableton AND Logic -- best overall chord assistant. Captain Plugins / Mixed in Key (~\$99 bundle, beginner-friendly). Hooktheory Hookpad + Aria AI (MIDI generation, educational). Logic Pro 12 Chord ID + Session Players (FREE in Logic): Chord ID turns any audio/MIDI into a chord progression; Synth/Bass/Keyboard/Drummer players follow it, can drive third-party plugins and convert to MIDI. You already own this -- it overlaps heavily with Scaler, so buy Scaler only for deeper harmonic exploration.

AI "tutor" / conversational in-DAW assistants. MixingGPT (in-DAW chat assistant, **VST/AU/AAX**; screenshot a plugin UI for feedback; trained on real mixes; rolling out via waitlist -- the most relevant live tutoring option). MixMate AI (~\$9.99/mo chat-based mix advice). WavTool (browser DAW with GPT-4 "Conductor" -- taken offline, likely acquired, not currently usable). FL Studio AI, Roland Melody Flip: emerging. Verdict: for tutoring inside your DAW, MixingGPT is the most relevant live option; for theory, Logic 12's free Chord ID/Session Players plus Scaler 3 cover you.

When to pay -- decision framework

Stay free if you're sketching ideas, learning, or making non-commercial/personal music. Free stack: Logic Stem Splitter + Mastering Assistant + Chord ID/Session Players, Ableton 12.3 stems, Demucs, Suno free / Stable Audio Open / Lyria in AI **Studio**, free Splice samples.

Pay when you cross a threshold: (1) commercial release of a generated track -> you MUST be on a paid tier (Suno Pro \$8/mo annual; ElevenLabs Starter \$5/mo; Stable Audio effectively free under the \$1M revenue threshold); free-tier output for sale violates ToS. (2) Need WAV/stem export or watermark removal -> paid tier. (3) Hitting generation limits repeatedly -> Pro tier. (4) Mastering 5+ tracks/year -> LANDR/eMastered (~\$19-30/mo) beats \$150+/track human mastering. (5) Want better fidelity/control inside the DAW -> one-time plugin purchases (Ozone, Scaler, Emergent Drums) -- no subscription, never expire.

Recommended STARTER paid stack (~25-35 EUR/mo equivalent): Suno Pro (\$8/mo annual, commercial generation + 12-stem export) + eMastered or LANDR (~\$18-28/mo, or skip if Logic's free Mastering Assistant is enough) + Splice x Ableton (\$12.99/mo) only if you want in-DAW sample search. Everything else free.

Recommended ALL-IN setup (no budget limit): Suno Premier (\$24/mo annual, Suno Studio + MIDI) + ElevenLabs Creator (\$11/mo, licensed-safe vocals) + Stable Audio paid + LANDR Pro (\$19/mo) + Splice Creator (\$19.99/mo). One-time: Ozone 12 Advanced

(\$499), Scaler 3 (~89 EUR), Emergent Drums 2 (~\$59), sonible smart:bundle. Net: ~70-90 EUR/month recurring + ~650-700 EUR one-time plugins.

Recommendations (staged)

Stage 0 (this week, 0 EUR): update to Logic Pro 12 and Ableton Live 12.3. Learn Logic's Chord ID + Session Players and Ableton's local stem separation. Run Suno free, Stable Audio Open and Lyria (AI Studio) to find which generator's character you like. Master a track with Logic's free Mastering Assistant. This alone covers most hobbyist needs.

Stage 1 (first paid step, ~8-13 EUR/mo): when you want to release commercially, subscribe to Suno Pro (best vocals + stem export) or ElevenLabs Starter (cheapest, cleanest licensing). Disclose AI use to your distributor -- DistroKid, RouteNote and Amuse accept AI with disclosure; CD Baby and TuneCore reject 100%-AI tracks. Keep subscription receipts and creation dates.

Stage 2 (quality tools you own, one-time): buy Scaler 3 (~89 EUR) for deeper harmony, Emergent Drums 2 (~\$59) for original royalty-free drums, and Ozone 12 Standard (\$219) or the sonible smart:bundle for mastering control you keep forever.

Stage 3 (scale up): if releasing regularly, add LANDR Pro (\$19/mo, mastering + distribution) or eMastered for warmth, and Splice for in-DAW AI sample search.

Benchmarks that change the plan: the Suno fair-use ruling -- a summary-judgment hearing in the District of Massachusetts (before Chief Judge F. Dennis Saylor IV) was reported for July 2026, though one docket-tracker reports the UMG v. Suno motions pushed to Jan. 8, 2027; confirm the date. If Suno loses on fair use, expect price/terms upheaval -- favor Stable Audio/ElevenLabs/Lyria (licensed) for anything you monetize. If Udio's 2026 licensed platform restores exports, re-evaluate it for its 48kHz fidelity. Crossing ~5 mastered tracks/year flips the math toward a mastering subscription.

Caveats

Copyright is not the same as a commercial license: paid AI tiers grant permission to use/sell, not registrable copyright. Pure-AI output generally isn't copyrightable in the US/EU without meaningful human authorship -- so your human production work (arrangement, mixing, added instrumentation in Ableton/Logic) is what makes a release defensible. Use generators as stems/ideas you build on, not as finished masters. Distributor risk: uploading undisclosed AI music risks takedowns and withheld royalties; detection is increasingly automated -- disclose and document your human contribution. Pricing is volatile; USD figures are list prices and Spanish VAT (21%) is typically added at checkout -- verify on each vendor's page. Udio is currently a dead end for DAW work until downloads return. Riffusion's

commercial terms are undocumented. Data/EU: US SaaS process your audio on US servers (a GDPR consideration for unreleased material); local tools keep audio on your machine. The court-date conflict noted above is unresolved in public reporting -- treat the litigation timeline as fluid.